Sunday, December 3

Let's try to get a picture of the overall situation as seen from Israel. Internally, we have a population that has experienced shocking events, that is in part traumatized, but which nonetheless overcame previous deep divisions and is ready to volunteer for service beyond expectations. Yet it is not clear how far this same population is confident in its political and military leadership. Probably, the population bears with the leadership because the country is at war. The leadership itself is deeply divided: Netanyahu hates Defense Minister Gallant; Gallant keeps close to Gantz and as far away from Netanyahu as possible. The extremists Ben-Gvir and Smotrich know that their time is limited and try to accumulate as many advantages as possible. Mainly, the PM holds the army command responsible for October 7 and deftly alludes to its responsibility for the catastrophe whenever he has the chance. Yet most of the population knows that he is the main culprit and that, at the first real opportunity, he has to go.

Externally, Israel is on the eve of a new offensive in Gaza-South, which according to the IDF may take months. However, the US is not ready to give it months—possibly weeks, at most. World opinion will become increasingly hostile as time goes by and the situation becomes more dire for the civilian population of Gaza. Israel may have to stop its offensive without achieving its aims: defeating Hamas, putting an end to its presence in Gaza, and retrieving the Israeli hostages. At the same time, the Jewish state is fighting Hezbollah in the North and is threatened by the Houthis along the Red Sea. As for the West Bank, it is a volcano waiting to erupt. Over all of these threats hovers the shadow of Iran, held back only by the presence in the region of the United States. For Israel, internally and externally, this is a war for its very existence.

Incidentally, there is something strangely similar between October 6, 1973, and October 7, 2023: our hubris, the sense, in the IDF and Israeli society at large, that the Arabs are incapable … in the first case, incapable